

organized forces. In addition, the South's rudimentary road and rail network made the transportation of men and equipment a nightmare for any invading army.

While the Confederates could see British struggles against the sweep of American geography during the American Revolution as a heartening example for their own war of independence, they could also draw lessons from the eventual collapse of British political will at the time. During the Revolution, internal divisions in Britain allowed the Americans to exhaust their former rulers and win independence. In the Civil War, while the fall of Fort Sumter unified Northern opinion behind a struggle for Union, what Union essentially meant remained a point of political contention, even among Republicans.

Questions of Federal authority, involving issues such as emancipation, conscription, and the draft, would be points of controversy in the North. For their part, the Confederates were united behind the overriding goal of sovereign independence.

Even the South's enslaved population gave the Confederates certain logistical advantages. An economy based on slavery and cotton-cultivation allowed the Confederacy to mobilize an unprecedented percentage of its white male population. Because fewer white men of military age were needed to keep the basic domestic economy running, around three out of four of them became soldiers—and one in five would die during the war. Eventually, however, the Union benefited from the support of Black Americans living in the Confederacy who enlisted as U.S. soldiers.